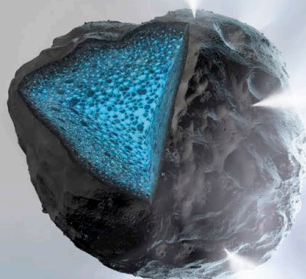


INSIDE A COMET



The heart of a comet is its solid nucleus, shown in this cut-away image. This “dirty snowball”, typically a few kilometres across, is made of ice and rocky dust left over from the birth of the Solar System. When heated by the Sun’s warmth, jets of gas burst through the dark, rocky crust.

Particles streaming outwards from the Sun propel the comet’s gas into a second, narrower tail

A chunk from a comet hit Earth 66 million years ago, **wiping out the dinosaurs.**

DATA FILE



MAXIMUM DISTANCE FROM THE SUN:
10 trillion km (6.2 trillion miles)



SMALLEST NUCLEUS: Comet 322P/SOHO, 0.2 km (0.12 miles) in diameter



LARGEST NUCLEUS: Comet Hale-Bopp, 60 km (37 miles) in diameter